

CDN Incident Alert: 0114. TLP: CLEAR**Date****Title** HU Persistent Infrastructure and Cross-Border Influence Operations Targeting European Elections on X

13/04/2026

Summary

- A network of over 550 inauthentic accounts was deployed to manipulate X's recommender algorithm during the October 2025 Dutch parliamentary elections and April 2026 Hungarian elections. The network, operated primarily from Nigeria and other West African countries, used mass following and retweeting to artificially amplify far-right and pro-Russian content. The same assets required only superficial profile modifications to pivot between two distinct national electoral contexts, demonstrating the low operational cost and high reusability of the infrastructure.
- The operation sought to manufacture the appearance of authentic domestic support for Eurosceptic, pro-Orbán, and pro-Russian political positions in both the Netherlands and Hungary.
- The network artificially inflated the follower counts and algorithmic reach of targeted political accounts, Hungarian assets receiving 22,082 unique followers.
- The operations cultivate support for aligning voices and boost their reputation, a technique by seemingly acquiring a botnet that uses automated forwarding and reposting to manipulate the platform algorithm.
- The case was escalated through the media, being published in 80+ publications. Platform-level structural vulnerabilities enabling follower-graph manipulation must be addressed through enforceable regulatory requirements, as reactive and partial account suspensions have proven insufficient to disrupt the operational capacity of persistent influence infrastructure.

Incident

During the Dutch (October 2025) and Hungarian (April 2026) elections, a coordinated inauthentic network of over 550 accounts, located primarily in Nigeria, conducted mass retweeting and following of small hyperactive accounts. The CIB accounts impersonated Dutch, Hungarian, and other public figures, with accounts cycling through identities while maintaining the same operational function; the same assets were repurposed from the Dutch to the Hungarian electoral context with minimal modification. The accounts were manipulating X's recommender algorithm into surfacing polarising, Eurosceptic, and pro-Russian content to genuine users, fabricating the appearance of organic domestic support. The posts and accounts that were amplified have been propagating far-right, anti-institutional, pro-FvD, pro-Orbán, and pro-Russian content in Dutch and Hungarian languages. The content was mostly targeted at the Dutch and Hungarian general publics, with the intent of artificially inflating the apparent social credibility and reach of targeted political accounts, as well as the general harmful narratives on X. The Dutch operation comprised over 550 identified inauthentic accounts; the same infrastructure was subsequently redeployed ahead of the Hungarian elections in 2026, where 1,770 CIB accounts geolocated to West Africa and Asia were found systematically following 21 targeted Hungarian accounts. Of these, at least 1,040 followers were traced to Nigeria alone. Follower overlap analysis further revealed that 16.8% of the 22,082 unique followers identified across the 21 Hungarian accounts appeared as followers of two or more accounts simultaneously, a pattern consistent with coordinated inauthentic behaviour rather than organic audience growth.

Narrative

Meta-narrative 1: Legitimate, grassroots populist and nationalist sentiment is growing organically across Europe, opposing EU institutions, NATO, and Western military support for Ukraine.

Sub-Narrative 1-1: Forum for Democracy in the Netherlands represents authentic popular resistance to an out-of-touch political establishment.

Sub-Narrative 1-2: Fidesz/Orbán in Hungary represents authentic popular resistance to an out-of-touch political establishment.

Impact and Outcome

Reach: The 21 identified Hungarian target accounts collectively accumulated 22,082 unique followers, of whom an estimated 1,770 were confirmed CIB accounts geolocated to West Africa and Asia.

Outcome: The Netherlands Authority for Consumers and Markets deferred oversight responsibility to the European Commission, which confirmed an ongoing investigation into whether X had done enough to protect the integrity of European elections.

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective 1: [T0136.004: Boost Reputation](#) - The CIB networks aimed to garner support for the countries' respective far-right parties by boosting friendly content via the recommender algorithm on X.

Objective 2: [T0136.006: Cultivate Support for Ally](#) - The CIB network has been attempting to control public discourse to interfere in the countries' elections by covertly favouring a party or candidate aligned with the presumed Russian interests.

[T0093.002: Acquire Botnets](#): The CIB network operates by using bot accounts on X, to boost the recommender algorithm and simulate perceived popular support for Orban and FvD.

[T0049.003: Bots Amplify via Automated Forwarding and Reposting](#): The botnetwork mass-follows and retweets content

[T0121: Manipulate Platform Algorithm](#): This is done to boost the recommender algorithm and simulate the perceived popular support for Orban and FvD.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: X suspended a portion of identified accounts following publication, but left the majority of the network intact and active, including some accounts flagged in both the Dutch and Hungarian datasets. The case was sent to the media, leading to over 80 articles being published.

Recommendation: X should address the underlying platform vulnerabilities enabling algorithm manipulation, rather than conducting partial, reactive account suspensions that leave broader network infrastructure intact. Given that X has also removed publicly visible engagement metrics such as post likes (reducing researchers' detection capabilities without impeding threat actors), regulators should mandate transparency measures that preserve independent monitoring capacity.

Report	Threat Actor	Authors	Platforms	FIMI assessment
Link	N/A	Maria Voltsichina, Alliance4Europe; Robert van der Noordaa, Trollrensics	X	Medium Certainty